

Ransomware Tabletop Exercise

Executive Leadership Tabletop Exercise

Organization: EastAfrica Retail Ltd

Industry: Retail

Employees: 50

Exercise Duration: 90 Minutes

Scenario Type: Double-Extortion Ransomware Attack

Exercise Objectives

This tabletop exercise is designed to evaluate executive-level decision-making during a ransomware incident affecting retail operations, customer data, and public reputation.

Objectives:

1. Assess executive response under pressure.
2. Evaluate business continuity planning.
3. Test communication and legal decision-making.
4. Examine ransomware response procedures.
5. Identify gaps in organizational preparedness.

Scenario Overview

EastAfrica Retail Ltd operates physical retail stores in Nairobi, Kisumu, and Mombasa, alongside an online ordering platform and customer loyalty program.

A threat actor known as BlackCobra Ransom Group gains access through a phishing email, steals credentials, moves laterally through the network, exfiltrates sensitive customer information, and deploys ransomware.

The executive team must make strategic decisions as the situation escalates.

Injection 1 – Initial Incident (00:00)

Situation

Monday 08:15 EAT

Multiple employees report they cannot access shared company files.

Several workstations display:

«"Your files have been encrypted."»

IT staff report suspicious overnight activity but cannot yet determine the scope.

Decisions Required

- Declare a security incident?
- Activate the incident response process?
- Inform executive leadership?
- Shut down critical systems?

Injection 2 – Operational Impact (00:20)

Situation

Twenty minutes later, IT confirms:

- Domain controller compromise
- Inventory management outage
- Online ordering platform unavailable

Estimated business loss:

\$5,000 per hour

Decisions Required

- Disconnect systems from the network?
- Continue operations manually?
- Notify cyber-insurance provider?
- Engage external incident response support?

Injection 3 – Data Theft Claim (00:40)

Situation

The attacker sends an email claiming:

- 120,000 customer records stolen
- Payment information accessed
- Data will be published within 72 hours

Evidence screenshots accompany the message.

Decisions Required

- Notify regulators?
- Notify customers?
- Validate exfiltration claims?
- Consider ransom negotiations?

Injection 4 – Media and Public Pressure (01:00)

Situation

A journalist contacts the company requesting comment.

Questions include:

- Was customer information stolen?
- Were payment systems compromised?
- Are stores closing?

Social media discussion is rapidly increasing.

Decisions Required

- Issue a public statement?
- Confirm the incident publicly?
- Delay comment until more facts are available?
- Prepare customer communications?

Executive Role Briefs

CEO

Knows

- Reputation is critical.
- Board expects regular updates.
- Customers trust the company.

Does Not Know

- Exact scope of compromise.
- Whether customer data was stolen.
- Recovery timeline.

Focus

- Strategic leadership
- Business continuity
- Stakeholder confidence

COO

Knows

- Retail operations depend on inventory and POS systems.
- Store managers are reporting disruptions.

Does Not Know

- Duration of outages.
- Full operational impact.

Focus

- Store continuity
- Inventory management
- Operational resilience

CFO

Knows

- Revenue losses are increasing.
- Cyber-insurance coverage exists.

Does Not Know

- Total financial impact.
- Insurance coverage limitations.

Focus

- Financial impact
- Insurance coordination
- Ransom-payment considerations

General Counsel

Knows

- Regulatory obligations may apply.
- Legal consequences may follow a breach.

Does Not Know

- Whether customer data was confirmed stolen.

Focus

- Legal compliance
- Regulatory reporting
- Contractual obligations

Head of Communications

Knows

- Public trust is essential.
- Journalists may publish before facts are confirmed.

Does Not Know

- Full scope of compromise.
- Exact recovery timeline.

Focus

- Public messaging
- Media engagement
- Customer communications

Facilitator Opening Script

Welcome everyone.

Today we will conduct a ransomware tabletop exercise.

This is a discussion-based exercise designed to evaluate decision-making under pressure.

There are no perfect answers.

The objective is to protect customers, maintain operations, and minimize business impact.

Please respond as you would during a real incident.

The exercise will last approximately 90 minutes.

Let's begin.

Exercise Timeline

Time| Activity

00:00| Injection 1

00:20| Injection 2

00:40| Injection 3

01:00| Injection 4

01:20| Final Discussion

01:25| Lessons Learned

01:30| Exercise Ends

Decision Log Template

Time| Decision| Owner| Reasoning

After-Action Review Template

Executive Summary

Describe overall exercise performance and major observations.

What Went Well

Document strengths observed during the exercise.

Challenges Identified

Document weaknesses, delays, or confusion.

Decisions That Worked

List effective decisions and why they succeeded.

Decisions That Failed

List ineffective decisions and lessons learned.

Recommended Improvements

Document actions required to improve readiness.

Action Items

Action| Owner| Priority| Due Date

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Facilitator Closing Script

Thank you for participating.

Today's exercise highlighted strengths, weaknesses, and opportunities for improvement.

The purpose was not to achieve perfect decisions but to identify areas requiring additional preparation.

All observations should be documented and converted into action items.

The exercise is now complete.